

Researchers have suggested that the real question we need to ask when it comes to nature and nurture isn't whether one is more important than the other but rather: How much does each affect us? Certainly, when it comes to our finances, it's a great question to ask, along with the follow-up question: Is how I'm demonstrating that particular trait or experience serving or sabotaging me? These are two important questions we're going to come back to again and again as we observe, recognise and create financial systems that are right for your unique Financial Phenotype.

The key word is 'recognise'.

If you remember, the definition of a phenotype is the observable 'appearance of an organism resulting from the interaction of the genotype and the environment'. In other words, it's the observed patterns, characteristics and effects of nature and nurture on a living being.

The problem when it comes to observing financial characteristics is that we're not used to talking about money, we're not regularly telling financial stories and we're certainly not encouraged to look for and recognise patterns in our own financial behaviour. In fact, we're often taught to shut down or dismiss conversations about money because they're 'rude' or 'impolite'. Even in my own family, with a father who was an accountant, money and investing weren't subjects we talked about. I know other families where innocent questions about earnings and salaries were, and often still are, shut down as 'bad mannered'. Only a few years ago in Australia, a well-known female media figure publicly called conversations about money and salaries 'crass'. Is it any wonder we're not keen to talk openly about our finances?

The sad truth is that as a result of these messages many of us simply don't feel comfortable talking about money. Or thinking about it. It's awkward and icky, and for some of us there's an element of shame involved.

That's why, before we start looking at financial examples, I'm going to look at the patterns, characteristics and effects of nature and nurture on physical structures—on bodies.

If we look at our height and weight, we may identify a genotype for how tall we might grow or the shape of our body, but our environment can have a far greater influence on these characteristics. If we grow up in an environment where good food, sunlight and exercise are plentiful, we'll